THE NEXT 100

SPORTS

STEADY AT THE CREASE

SMRITI MANDHANA, 25

Cricketer, Sangli, Maharashtra

"Every time I step on to the field, it's like, 'Smriti you have to score runs.' I love responsibility"



MANDAR DEODHAR, Makeup: Sharvari Gandhe

Smriti Mandhana was always a precocious talent, just nine when she made it to the Maharashtra Under-15 team, 11 when she was drafted into the state Under-19 team. She donned the blue Indian jersey for the first time in the summer of 2013. She was just 16 then. Since then, her rise has been phenomenal, so much so she's already one of India's most successful batters.

With runs and experience under her belt and an affable personality, it's just a matter of time before Smriti is handed the Indian captaincy. She's also on the radar of every franchise/ team when it comes to foreign leagues like the Women's Big Bash League and The Hundred. Success brings with it a lot of expectations and Smriti acknowledges both sides of the fame bit. "As an opener, we have to lay the platform for the innings. As a team, we want to win the World Cup. If people appreciate you, one should also be ready for criticism. If people are criticising, it means they are watching you," reckons Smriti.

With four ODI tons, she is already closing in on the record for most centuries by an Indian woman in ODIs. Only Mithali Raj, who has been at the crease since 1999, is ahead of her. Her ability to adapt to conditions, be it foreign or Indian, makes her a force to reckon with. Interestingly, all five of her centuries for India came on foreign soil. ■

–Rahul Rawat

TWICE AS NICE Mandhana is the first Indian woman to score a double century in a domestic one-dayer, 224 n.o. in a West Zone U-19 game.